

Broiled polenta with chipotle–mushroom ragout

While the previous recipe relies mostly on the beauty of simplicity, this highlights a slightly more complex sauce that is **brash** in its savory heat and spice. Rather than featuring a mushlike polenta, this dish carries the day with polenta formed into a cake, then set under the broiler to slightly brown the top—offering an equally tasty result.

1 recipe Basic Polenta (page 216)

5 dried porcini or other dried mushrooms

1 to 2 chipotle chiles or 1 teaspoon chipotle chile powder

1 medium onion, finely chopped

3 tablespoons olive oil

2 garlic cloves, minced

5 ounces fresh shiitake mushrooms, stemmed, caps thinly sliced [150g]

½ pound white button or cremini mushrooms, thinly sliced [250g]

2 tablespoons tomato paste

1 tablespoon balsamic vinegar

Salt and freshly ground pepper

¼ cup coarsely chopped parsley [60ml]

1. Prepare the Basic Polenta and **pour** it into a lightly oiled 9-inch [23-cm] pie plate or a loaf pan. Refrigerate until cool and firm, at least 2 hours.
2. **Soak** the dried mushrooms in 1 cup [250g] hot water until soft, 15 to 20 minutes. Lift out the mushrooms and squeeze excess liquid from them back into the bowl. Finely chop the mushrooms. Strain the mushroom soaking liquid through a coffee filter or double thickness of cheesecloth and set aside.
3. Crack open the chipotle chile(s), remove the seeds, and soak in hot water until soft, 20 to 30 minutes. **Mince** the chile(s) and set aside.

4. In a large skillet, **cook** the onion in the oil over medium heat until soft and lightly browned, 5 to 7 minutes. Add the garlic, fresh and dried mushrooms, and chipotle chile. Cook an additional 4 to 5 minutes, or until the mushrooms are tender.
5. **Add** the reserved mushroom soaking liquid and bring to a boil. Cook until the liquid is reduced by about half. Reduce the heat slightly and blend in the tomato paste. Cook until thick, about 5 minutes longer, stirring frequently. Add the vinegar. Remove from the heat and season with salt and pepper to taste.
6. Preheat the broiler with the rack set 4 to 5 inches [10 to 13cm] from the heat. **Brush** the polenta with olive oil and broil for 1 to 2 minutes, or until slightly browned and just a touch crispy. Watch carefully so it doesn't burn. Cut into 4 to 6 triangles. Ladle the mushroom ragout over each piece of polenta. Garnish with parsley and serve.

SERVES 4 AS AN ENTREE, 6 AS AN APPETIZER

